POLICY REVIEW / DRAFT FOR REVIEW

Beyond AI Literacy: Youth Participation in Hong Kong's AI and Sustainable Development Agenda

A Rapid Review of Hong Kong Government Policy Documents, 2025–2026

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Executive Summary

This review asks how Hong Kong policy supports youth AI capability, research and innovation, and responsible-AI governance. The selected documents specify education and training routes, youth-facing research and experiential opportunities, and emerging risk-management measures. [E05] [E06] [E08] [E11] [E12] [E15]

Most youth-specific measures reviewed focus on learning, training, exposure, and research or career pathways. The cited AI-governance provisions describe institutional safeguards but do not specify a standing youth role in governance or evaluation. This is a bounded observation about the documents selected, not evidence that no such channel exists elsewhere. Announced budgets, targets, and pilots are treated as policy commitments rather than verified results.

Policy Context

The review examines the First Five-Year Plan (2026–2030), the 2025 and 2026 Policy Addresses, the 2026–27 Budget, the Education Bureau's 2026 Digital Education Blueprint, and the Digital Policy Office's 2025 generative-AI guideline, version 1.1. The 2022 Youth Development Blueprint is background only. The Plan and 2026 Address were issued on 16 September 2026. [E01] [E05] [E06] [E08] [E10] [E17]

Evidence IDs link claims to the policy evidence matrix. The SDG references are YouthAISD's analytical mappings: AI skills to target 4.4, research capacity to 9.5, accountable institutions and participation to 16.6 and 16.7, and climate policy integration to 13.2. They are not government classifications: skills [U04], research [U09], governance and participation [U16], and climate [U13].

Observation 1: AI Literacy and Youth Capacity

The 2025 Policy Address set aside HK$2 billion under the Quality Education Fund for school digital education and proposed AI literacy. Released in June 2026, the Education Bureau's Blueprint defines student AI literacy through knowledge, skills, and values. It requires at least 30 digital-education training hours within each teacher's three-year CPD cycle and sets a separate annual target of 50,000 training places. These are specified measures, not evidence of student outcomes. [E05] [E06] [E07]

The 2026–27 Budget committed HK$50 million to public, tertiary, and industry collaboration on AI courses, seminars, and competitions for students, young people, and the public. It also directs UGC-funded universities to introduce 27 STEAM-related undergraduate programmes in total during 2025/26–2027/28, including AI, creative industries, and data science—not 27 AI-only degrees. The 2026 Policy Address targets more than 200 public AI courses and activities by Q1 2028. Delivery and participation were not assessed. YouthAISD maps this capacity-building strand to target 4.4. [E08] [E09] [E10] [U04]

Observation 2: Youth Participation in AI Innovation

The 2026 Policy Address names several routes beyond general literacy. It announces new AI experiential activities for young people; an increase in places on high-end scientific-research internships at the Chinese Academy of Sciences; and a young-researcher category under the Innovation and Technology Support Programme. The internship measure is a broad research opportunity, not a specifically AI-focused placement in the cited provision. [E11] [E12] [E13]

Talent Foundry, expanded by the Hong Kong Science and Technology Parks Corporation, focuses on AI+ and emerging technologies. Around 500 annual training opportunities are expected for local university students, researchers, career newcomers, and professionals. The cited provisions do not verify participant access or outcomes. YouthAISD maps research capacity broadly to target 9.5. [E14] [U09]

Observation 3: Responsible AI and Sustainable Development

The First Five-Year Plan directs a review of legislation and development of an AI and data governance framework alongside AI expansion. The 2026 Policy Address identifies seven risk areas: criminal misuse, minors' protection, ethics, application safety, product liability, AI-agent safety, and impact assessment. Selected departments will pilot bidder safety and ethics declarations for public-facing AI projects; wider extension depends on the results. The DPO's version 1.1 is published guidance. These measures are at different stages, not a uniformly enforced regime. YouthAISD maps governance to target 16.6. [E02] [E15] [E16] [E17] [U16]

Separately, the Plan targets ending coal use for daily electricity generation by 2035 and raising zero-carbon energy to about 60–70 per cent. The reviewed texts do not establish a common requirement to assess AI initiatives against climate outcomes. This warrants programme-level follow-up; it does not prove no such assessment exists. YouthAISD maps the climate-planning measure to target 13.2. [E04] [U13]

A Gap Worth Examining

The selected documents most clearly position young people as learners, users, trainees, and participants in research or career development. They also set out institutional and procurement safeguards for AI. In the cited AI-governance provisions, however, no standing process is specified for young people to help design, test, or evaluate public-facing AI systems. The Plan's broader invitation for youth exchanges on public affairs and science is relevant civic context, but it is not described there as an AI-governance pathway. YouthAISD uses target 16.7 as a lens for the participation question, not as a government classification. [E03] [E11] [E12] [E13] [E14] [E15] [E16] [U16]

Taken together, the evidence points chiefly to capacity-building, while research and innovation pathways are also present. The selected clauses do not establish an ongoing youth role in AI governance or evaluation; this finding remains bounded by the documents and period reviewed.

Implications for Youth-led Initiatives

Youth-led groups could first publish a practical map of existing AI learning, internship, and research opportunities, showing eligibility, deadlines, responsible bodies, and whether each item is announced, open, or completed. This would help young people navigate measures without overstating access or delivery.

A second, bounded project could assess one publicly documented AI service using published information and transparent criteria, with privacy and safety safeguards and no need for privileged system access. YouthAISD could then send concise findings to the responsible programme owner and publish a record of any response. These are independent proposals, not existing government programmes or partnerships.

Limitations

This English-first review covers selected 2025–2026 official documents, using the 2022 Youth Development Blueprint as context and UN target descriptions for SDG mapping. It is not exhaustive of bureau circulars, programme pages, laws, or Chinese-language sources and includes no interviews, survey, implementation evaluation, or expert review.

Funding allocations, announced opportunities, targets, and pilots are reported as policy statements. Disbursement, uptake, access conditions, participation, compliance, and outcomes were not independently verified. Failure to find a youth-governance pathway in the selected texts is not evidence that no such pathway exists elsewhere.

Independence statement

> This brief is an independent youth-led policy review. It does not represent the views of, or imply endorsement by, the Government of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region.

References

Evidence IDs in the body link directly to official sources. SDG references are YouthAISD analytical mappings, not government classifications.

R1 — The First Five-Year Plan for Economic and Social Development of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (2026–2030), §§2.47, 5.12, 5.62 and Table 16.

- Official English full text (PDF) ■
- Official plan portal ■
- Official Government release record ■

R2 — The Chief Executive's 2025 Policy Address, paragraph 147.

- Paragraph 147 (official webpage) ■
- Full English text (PDF) ■

R3 — Education Bureau, Blueprint for Digital Education Development in Primary and Secondary Schools, Executive Summary (June 2026), and Education Bureau Circular No. 11/2026.

- Executive Summary (official PDF) ■
- Blueprint webpage ■
- Release circular (official PDF) ■

R4 — The 2026–27 Budget Speech, paragraphs 43–44.

- Official English text (PDF) ■
- AI training and STEAM programmes (official webpage) ■

R5 — The Chief Executive's 2026 Policy Address, Chapter III paragraphs 118, 122–123 and Chapter VII paragraphs 283–284.

- Chapter III: AI training and risk governance ■
- Chapter VII: youth and research pathways ■
- Official release record ■

R6 — Home and Youth Affairs Bureau, Youth Development Blueprint (December 2022), consulted as foundational context only.

- Official English document (PDF) ■
- Official download page ■

R7 — Digital Policy Office, Hong Kong Generative Artificial Intelligence Technical and Application Guideline, version 1.1 (December 2025).

- Official English guideline (PDF) ■
- AI and Data Ethics webpage ■

R8 — United Nations Sustainable Development Goals target descriptions used for analytical mappings.

- Goal 4 (targets 4.4) ■
- Goal 9 (target 9.5) ■
- Goal 13 (target 13.2) ■
- Goal 16 (targets 16.6 and 16.7) ■

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